

The texts of I Kings 16:29-22:51 and Amos identify evil as the target of God's anger. In particular, this section of I Kings describes the evil reign of Ahab, king of Israel, who "did evil in the sight of the Lord more than all [the evil kings] who were before him," (I Kg. 16:30). Likewise, the prophet Amos, as recorded in Scripture, identifies the time that Israel was living in as "an evil time," (Amos 5:13) and calls Israel to "seek good and not evil that you may live," (5:14). Recognizing that evil is the privation of good, it is apparent that the authors of I Kings and of Amos record a period of Israel's history where Israel strayed far away from God, the source and fullness of good.

I Kings records the evil reign of king Ahab as a reign marked by such prevalent economic injustice, idolatry, violence, and exploitation of the vulnerable that God called Elijah to intervene. In the middle of the 7 year drought which Elijah announces to Ahab as a warning, Ahab's poor administration led to great suffering and economic disparity throughout Israel. Much of I Kings 17 follows Elijah's interaction with a widow and her dying son, showing the destitute living faced by certain constituents of Ahab's rule. I Kings 18 reveals some of the religious evils of which Ahab is guilty, including: letting his wife, queen Jezebel, execute kill the prophets of the Lord (18:13), disobeying the Lord's commandments, and following the Baals (thus disbelieving in the Lord) (18:18). This is reaffirmed as his most evil action in God's sentence of him, "There was no one like Ahab, who sold himself to do what was evil in the sight of the Lord, urged on by his wife Jezebel. He acted most abominably in going after idols," (21:25-26). His rule also brought about both great violence with Syria (I Kings 20 recounts his wars with Ben-hadad) and a forbidden military alliance with Syria. The final straw, in God's eyes, is when Ahab steals the rightful inheritance that was bequeathed to Naboth in order to fulfill his own royal desires. Ahab conspired with his wife to steal Naboth's vineyard by publicly slandering him and having him killed in order to gain his material goods. All of these forms of evil treachery – economic injustice, idolatry, violence, and exploitation of the vulnerable – cause God to condemn Ahab. These actions are contrary to God's will and are therefore evil. God despises evil.

The Book of Amos is a prophetic exhortation that seeks to cast judgment upon the evil committed by Israel during this time and call Israel to repentance. Amos's message is not simply a call of condemnation *of* evil, but a call for transformation *from* evil back to living in right relationship with God, creation, and one another. Amos identifies several evil practices in Israel – particularly their empty religiosity and their social injustice. Many social ills are highlighted by Amos because caring for the destitute was enshrined in Mosaic law – by not caring for those in need, Israel was failing to fulfill its covenantal duty. This includes the ruling elite engaging in sexual immorality (2:7), extorting farmers (2:8), disregarding the reproof and truth spoken by the prophets (2:12, 5:10), "trampling" on the poor like dirt (2:7, 5:11, 8:4), stealing from them (3:10, 5:11), taking bribes (5:12), bringing violence (6:3), and reveling in self-indulgence (6:4-6). "Many are [their] transgressions... great are [their] sins," (5:12). In addition to social injustice, Israel was also guilty of vain religiosity. "I hate, I despise your festivals, and I take no delight in your solemn assemblies... I will not accept [your offerings], and... I will not look upon [your sacrifices]," (5:21-22). Amos's prophetic message also mixed these two areas of influence; he notably followed his condemnation of Israel's empty religiosity with a plea that Israel instead "let justice roll down like waters, and righteousness like an ever-flowing stream," (5:24). The issues of society and religion were largely interconnected in Amos's time, so it makes sense that his condemnation of Israel should so closely interconnect these two ideas to form one powerful exhortation against evil. By urging Israel to restore the balance between its religious

observances and social responsibilities, Amos highlights the enduring truth that true goodness is found in the pursuit of both ethical conduct and sincere devotion to God.

To further understand these ancient transgressions, it is useful to examine a contemporary example of similar evil. Both I Kings and Amos denounce the oppression of the vulnerable at the hands of the elite. While I Kings 21 recounts the story of Nabaoth, the man whose inheritance was stolen by the hands of a greedy, malicious ruler, Amos explicitly condemns such oppression when the text reads,

Hear this, you that trample on the needy,
and bring to ruin the poor of the land,
saying... “We will... practice deceit with false balances,
buying the poor for silver
and the needy for a pair of sandals,
and selling the sweepings of the wheat.”
The Lord has sworn by the pride of Jacob:
Surely I will never forget any of their deeds. (Amos 8:4-7).

These passages explicitly accuse the elite of committing economic evils toward the poor. This is reflected in the modern concept of “wage theft” – that is, the practice of unfair, unpaid, or withheld wages for work, especially at the hands of large corporations toward their employees. Large companies including Amazon, McDonald’s, and various other businesses have been known to force their employees to work without pay, deny fair wages, and exploit immigrant workers. Just like Ahab did to Nabaoth, these corporations manipulate their power and influence to “practice deceit with false balances” toward their employees at the employees’ expense. While the needy are bought with sandals, the corporations profit from selling the sweepings of wheat! The Catholic Church, acting in the place of prophets like Amos, condemns this misbehavior of corporations in its social teaching.

In the 1891 social encyclical *Rerum Novarum*, Pope Leo XIII writes “To defraud anyone of wages that are his due is a great crime which cries to the avenging anger of Heaven,” (§17). Clearly this practice is condemnable by God. Humans have an inherent dignity that demands fair treatment, and when employers deny workers their rightful wages, they commit a sin akin to that of Ahab and the corrupt elites Amos denounces. The Church further develops this teaching a century later in *Laborem Exercens* where Pope Saint John Paul II writes, “It is always morally illicit to use human beings as mere instruments of production and not as the true purpose of economic activity,” (§7). Wage theft is not just an economic issue but a deep social injustice that disrupts the dignity of work and exploits the most vulnerable. The prophet Amos warns that God will “never forget any of their deeds” (Amos 8:7), reminding the elite that economic injustice carries spiritual consequences. The consistent teaching of Scripture and Catholic Social Teaching makes it clear: economic exploitation is a grave evil that calls for justice, repentance, and reform, lest the elite find themselves, like Ahab, condemned by God.